

much time, while also paying attention to and listening to the speaker.

An interesting side-effect: if you keep things brief, you'll have the luxury of being able to use larger fonts. These have greater impact, naturally, and also make the slide readable for those at the back of the room.

Tip

Studies have long indicated that the concentrated human attention span is at a maximum of 30 or 40 minutes. This goes down drastically as numbers (as opposed to text and raw ideas) need to be absorbed. There's some scientific truth to the common idea that "numbers are boring."

2.1.2.4 Number numbness

This one is pretty straightforward. Don't throw in too many numbers and statistics. 75 out of 100 will probably not read them. 15 of the 25 from the 100 that read them will probably not comprehend them. And chances are 100 of the 100 will not appreciate them. Get the picture?

It's not just that your slides will be wasted upon the audience: it's also that the audience will take a silent dislike to you for throwing so many details at them. If a lot of numerical data must be conveyed, construct easy-to-visualise graphs or charts.

2.1.2.5 Sum it up

Here is a powerful way of making them take something home, like we said you should. If you just take the trouble to insert a summary slide or two—attractive, pretty ones—recall is that much better. This is for two reasons: first, the summary slide(s) reinforce what they've been witnessing for some time now; and second, even if they forget the rest of what was presented, the summary slide(s) will stay with them because it (they) came last and/or were short.

2.1.2.6 Be proper

The chain is no stronger than its weakest link, they (wise men, we presume) say. One or two spelling or grammar errors in a slide—and *that's* what they'll remember. It's not only the tendency to criticise